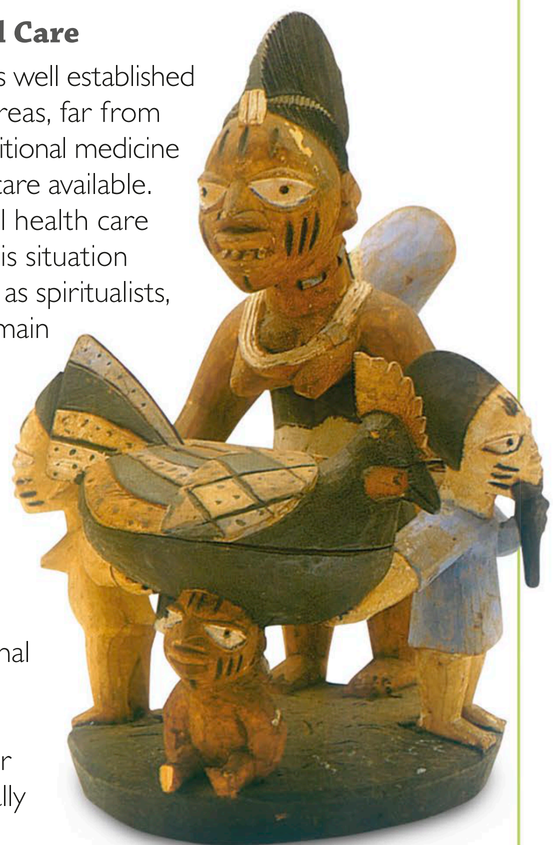
(*Tabernanthe iboga*), are chewed to combat fatigue, and are taken as intoxicants in religious ceremonies. According to local accounts in the Congo and Gabon, iboga's stimulant effect was discovered when observers saw wild boars and gorillas dig up and eat the roots, and subsequently become frenzied.

Traditional & Conventional Care

Conventional Western medicine is well established throughout Africa, but in rural areas, far from medical and hospital services, traditional medicine remains the only form of health care available. Even in urban areas conventional health care services can be limited, and in this situation traditional providers of care such as spiritualists, herbalists, and midwives are the main source of treatment available for the majority of the population. The World Health Organization aims to achieve a level of health care that will permit all people to lead socially and economically productive lives. In an attempt to meet this, African countries have pioneered the training of traditional medicine practitioners in simple medical techniques and basic hygiene procedures. In one center in Mampong, Ghana, conventionally trained medical staff work hand in hand with traditional herbal practitioners, encouraging the safer use of herbal medicines and researching them in detail. In nearby Kumasi, the university now offers a BS degree in herbal medicine. This represents a remarkable change in attitude. In the 19th and much of the 20th centuries, colonial governments and Christian missionaries viewed traditional herbalists as witch doctors, whose practices were best suppressed.



This Nigerian divination bowl *was used by traditional healers in the diagnosis of illness via the interpretation of magical signs.*

The Discovery of New Herbal Cures

Along with encouraging the safer use of herbal medicines, medical centers are researching their use in detail. The benefits of pygeum (*Pygeum africanum*, p. 260) have been conclusively established. This tree is traditionally used in central and southern Africa to treat urinary problems. Today, it is regularly prescribed in conventional French and Italian medicine for prostate problems. Of the plants under investigation in Africa, Kigelia (*Kigelia pinnata*, p. 225)—a sub-Saharan tree, and Sutherlandia (*Sutherlandia frutescens*)—a small South African shrub, are of particular interest. Kigelia has a marked ability to prevent and heal skin lesions, including psoriasis, while Sutherlandia is an adaptogen with anticancer activity.

The reevaluation of traditional herbal medicine in Africa may result in the acceptance of additional plant-based medicines. Today, the opportunity exists to combine the best of traditional practice with conventional medical knowledge, for mutual gain.